

| 2005 | NANAVATI COMMISSION REPORT

Delayed and Denied

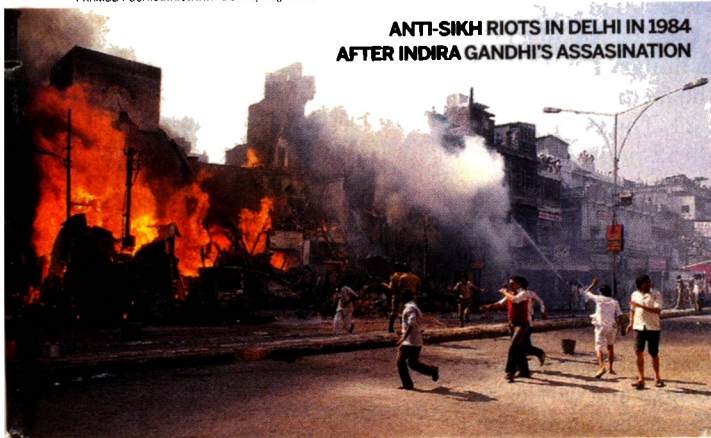
Twenty-one years were not long enough to heal the wounds of Sikhs

After the assassination of prime minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh guards on October 31, 1984, mayhem was unleashed against the Sikh community across the country. The worst affected was Delhi where over 3,000 Sikhs were killed, their women raped, their property looted and 72 gurdwaras burned in three days. It started on November 1, 1984, in east Delhi's Trilokpuri locality even as the Delhi Police watched in silence. While the carnage had the tacit support of local Youth Congress leaders who held ministerial positions in subsequent Congress governments, an artificial truth was manufactured that made people believe that it was a spontaneous outburst. Ironically, the first Sikh to be attacked was Giani Zail Singh, the President of India, on the day of the assassination. His entourage was stoned at AIIMS in Delhi. On his mother's birthday on November 19, 1984, Rajiv Gandhi, who by then was prime minister, said at Delhi's Boat Club even as the victims were still in the grip of terror, "We know the people were very angry and for a few days it

seemed India had been shaken. But when a mighty tree falls, it is only natural that the earth around it does shake a little." Then began the drama of commissions and omissions. There was one to examine the role of the police under Ved Marwah, which was replaced by the Justice Ranganath Mishra Commission in 1985 to probe if the violence was organised. In its August

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ANTI-SIKH RIOTS IN DELHI IN 1984
AFTER INDIRA GANDHI'S ASSASSINATION



1996 report, the commission recommended three new committees under R.K. Ahuja (to ascertain the number of people killed); Justice Dalip Kapur and Kusum Lata Mittal (to look at the role of the police); and Justice M.L. Jain and A.K. Banerjee (to investigate cases against Jagdish Tytler and Sajjan Kumar) then in December 1993, the Justice Ranjit Singh Narula Committee was appointed, the third panel in a decade to recommend cases against Tytler, Kumar and HKL Bhagat. In 2000, a one-man commission under retired Supreme Court judge Girish Thakorlal Nanavati was constituted by the NDA government to investigate the carnage. Nanavati submitted his report in February 2005, recommending action against Tytler, Kumar and Bhagat for instigating violent mobs against Sikhs. Nanavati also held the then police commissioner S.C. Tandon directly responsible for the riots. A few days after the Nanavati report, then prime minister Manmohan Singh said in Parliament, "I have no hesitation in apologising to not only the Sikh community but also to the nation. I bow my head in shame." Following this, Tytler resigned from the Union Cabinet, though both the Government and the CBI gave him a clean chit later. **by Mihir Srivastava**



DEMONSTRATORS DEMANDING
THE RIGHT TO INFORMATION ACT

THE MAIN EVENT

Right to Information Act

Gandhian and social activist Anna Hazare wanted to return his Padma Bhushan to President APJ Abdul Kalam on August 9, the anniversary of the Quit India Movement, but Kalam talked him out of it. Hazare left Rashtrapati Bhavan to join a countrywide crusade against the proposed changes in the Right to Information (RTI) Act 2005. Then the Union Cabinet decided to amend sections of the Act by including "file notings" in the list of exemptions from public scrutiny. The amendments that are likely to be introduced in the current session of Parliament will render the legislation "soulless", says Hazare. The fight to get the citizens a legal guarantee to demand information on government departments and public companies intensified a decade ago.

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ALSO

- President's Rule is imposed in Goa and Bihar
- Three serial blasts kill over 60 people in Delhi
- Sachin Tendulkar becomes the second Indian to score 10,000 runs in Test cricket

Indian Ocean Tsunami

Hit Indonesia, Sri Lanka, India and Thailand in 2004, killing 2.75 lakh people.

Kashmir Earthquake

Centred in PoK and NWFP. Killed 80,000, including 1,400 in J&K in 2005.

Hurricane Katrina

In 2005, 1,836 people were killed in the US, mostly in New Orleans, which was the worst-hit.

Sichuan Earthquake

Nearly 70,000 died and 3,74,176 were hurt in 2008 in China. Still missing: 18,222 people.

Sumatra Earthquake

Hit southern Indonesia in 2009; 1,115 dead, 1,214 hurt, lakhs of houses damaged.